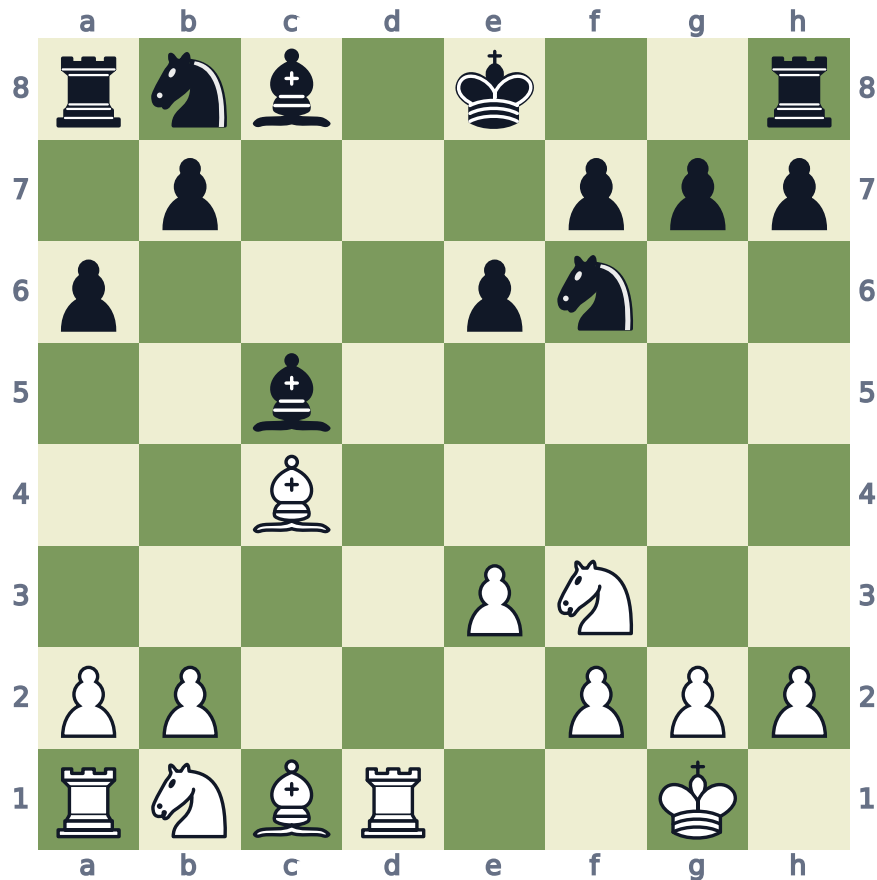


Queen's Gambit Accepted and Independent Defenses

Recovering c4, building the center, and meeting Chigorin, Baltic, and Marshall ideas



Respond to early independence from Black without chasing the c4-pawn blindly or neglecting development.

8 learning units | diagrams | recall tests | engine-checked analysis

ORIENTATION

How to study this volume

PURPOSE

Respond to early independence from Black without chasing the c4-pawn blindly or neglecting development.

THE TRAINING LOOP

- First identify Black's defense from pawn placement and move order.
- At every diagram, name the center, the urgent threat, and two candidate moves.
- Hide the recall answer until you have spoken the move and its purpose.
- Replay each line from both sides in Fritz or another board program.
- Review misses after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.
-

WHAT COMPLETE MEANS HERE

This volume contains 8 units inside a connected White repertoire. It covers the main structural and move-order decisions you need for practical play; the PGN companion makes later updating possible.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 1-3

PRINCIPLE 1

The c4-pawn is usually recovered through development, not pawn chasing.

PRINCIPLE 2

Central occupation with e4 is powerful only when tactics permit it.

PRINCIPLE 3

Open lines make king safety and development urgent.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

STRATEGIC FOUNDATION

Principles 4-6

PRINCIPLE 4

Against ...Nc6, challenge d5 before Black gains free activity.

PRINCIPLE 5

Against an early bishop sortie, ask what central square was neglected.

PRINCIPLE 6

Accept equality when it preserves a healthy structure and active pieces.

VERIFICATION QUESTION

What would have to be true for one of these principles to be wrong in the current position? Check forcing moves before applying a strategic rule.

REPERTOIRE MAP

Branches 1-8

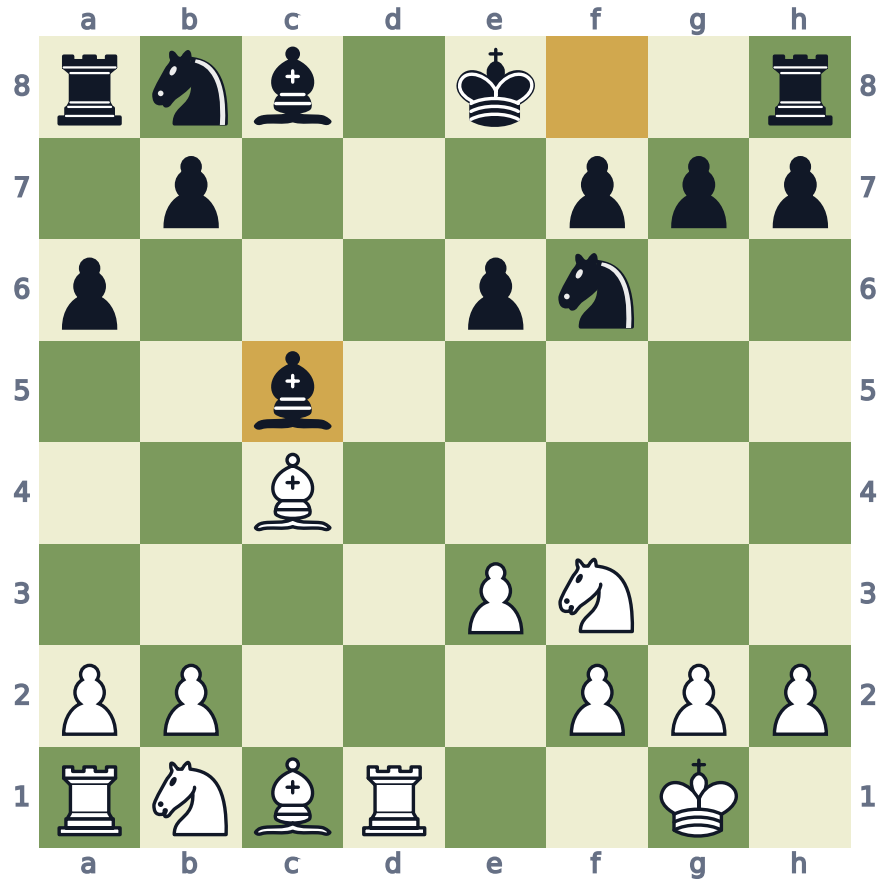
- | | | |
|-----------|-------------------------------|--|
| 01 | QGA classical recovery | Bxc4 plus O-O is the reliable recovery sequence. |
|
 | | |
| 02 | QGA ...b5 expansion | Attack the base of ...b5 with a4 or b3. |
|
 | | |
| 03 | QGA central strike | When Black plays ...c5, decide whether tension or exchange favors development. |
|
 | | |
| 04 | Early e4 in the QGA | e4 is ambitious; checks on b4 are Black's forcing reply. |
|
 | | |
| 05 | Chigorin Defense | ...Nc6 blocks the c-pawn, so challenge d5 early. |
|
 | | |
| 06 | Baltic Defense | An early ...Bf5 leaves b7 and the queen side sensitive to Qa4+. |
|
 | | |
| 07 | Marshall Defense | ...Nf6 without ...e6 or ...c6 permits cxd5 and e4. |
|
 | | |
| 08 | QGA quiet line | A recovered pawn plus completed development is already a successful opening. |

NAVIGATION RULE

Identify the pawn structure first, then confirm the move order. A familiar position reached by a different sequence should trigger the same plan.

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 01

QGA classical recovery



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. Bxc4 c5 6. O-O a6 7. dxc5 Qxd1 8. Rxd1 Bxc5

WHITE'S IDEA

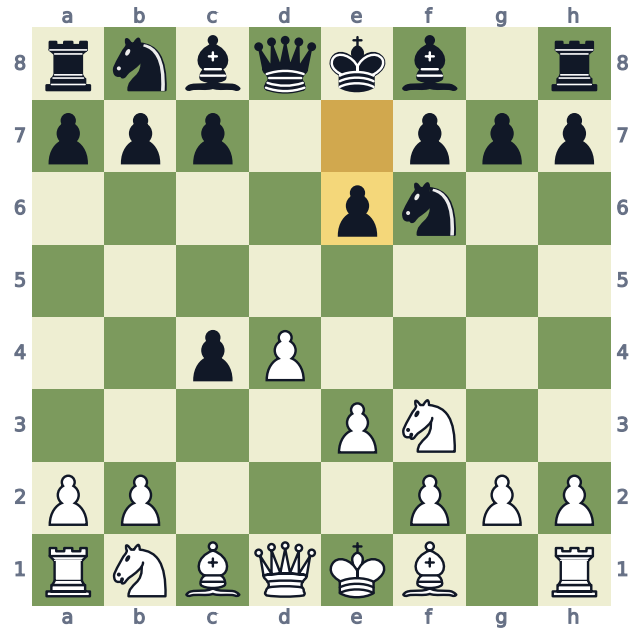
Recover c4 through development and accept a clean active endgame.

MAIN DANGER

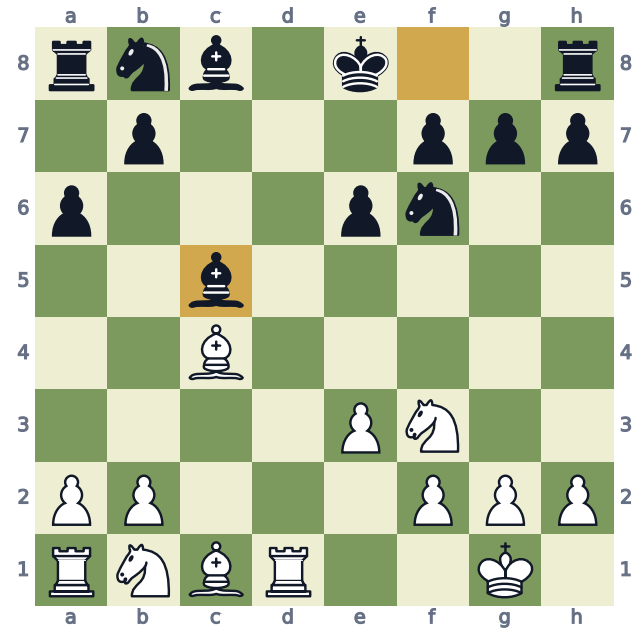
Do not fear queen trades when development and structure are healthy.

BRANCH LOGIC 01

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 8 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Bxc4 plus O-O is the reliable recovery sequence.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

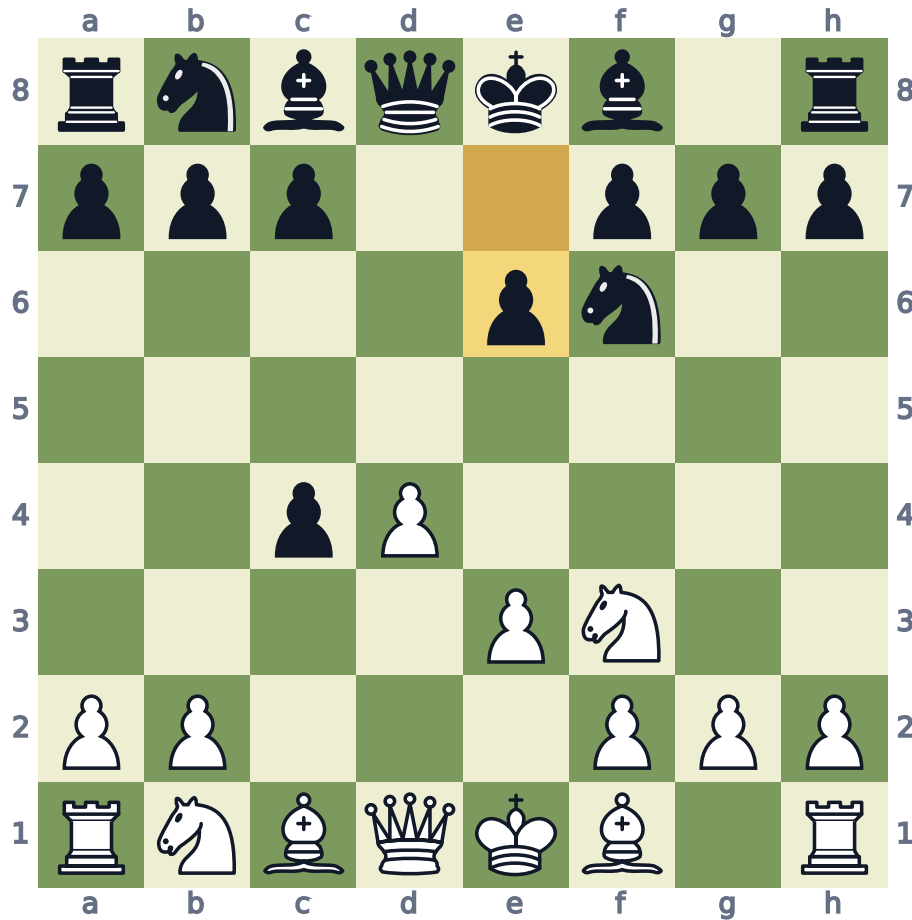
Position estimate: +0.35 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Be2 O-O 2. Ne5 Nbd7 3. Nc4 Nb6 4. Na5 Nbd5 5. Nd2 b6

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 01

QGA classical recovery



YOUR TASK

White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 02

QGA ...b5 expansion



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 b5 5. a4 c6 6. axb5 cxb5 7. b3

WHITE'S IDEA

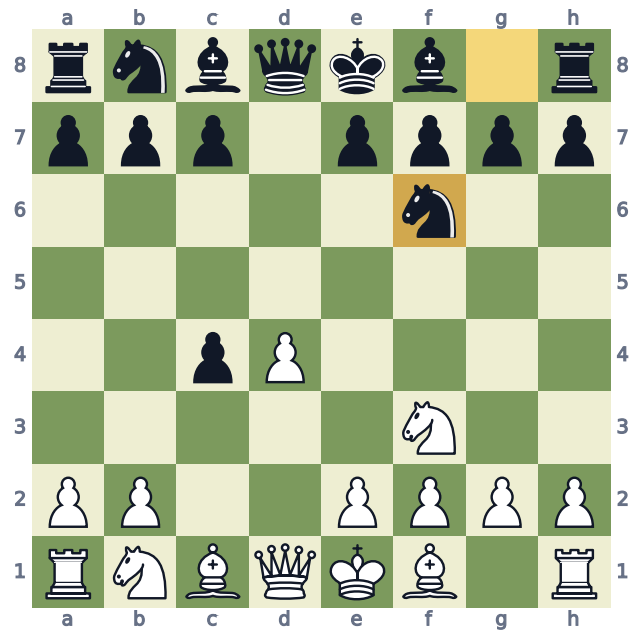
Undermine the pawn chain rather than chase its front pawn.

MAIN DANGER

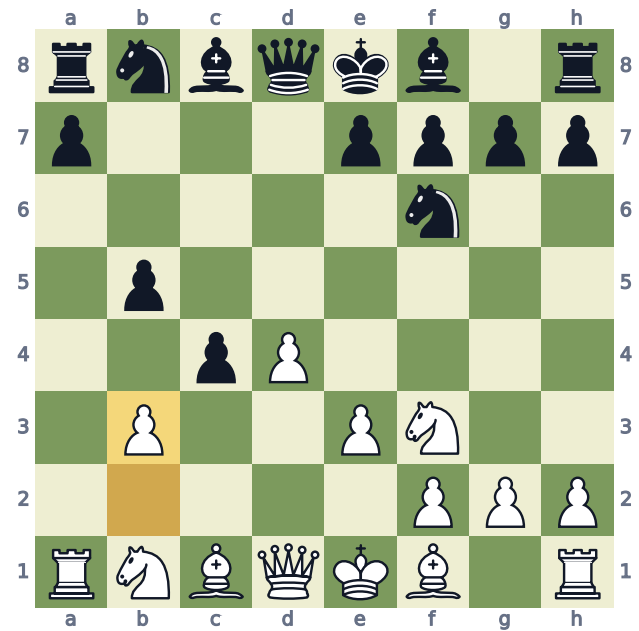
Opening the a-file can expose the rook if geometry is ignored.

BRANCH LOGIC 02

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

Attack the base of ...b5 with a4 or b3.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.31 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. e6 bxc4 2. bxc4 Bxc4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 02

QGA ...b5 expansion



YOUR TASK

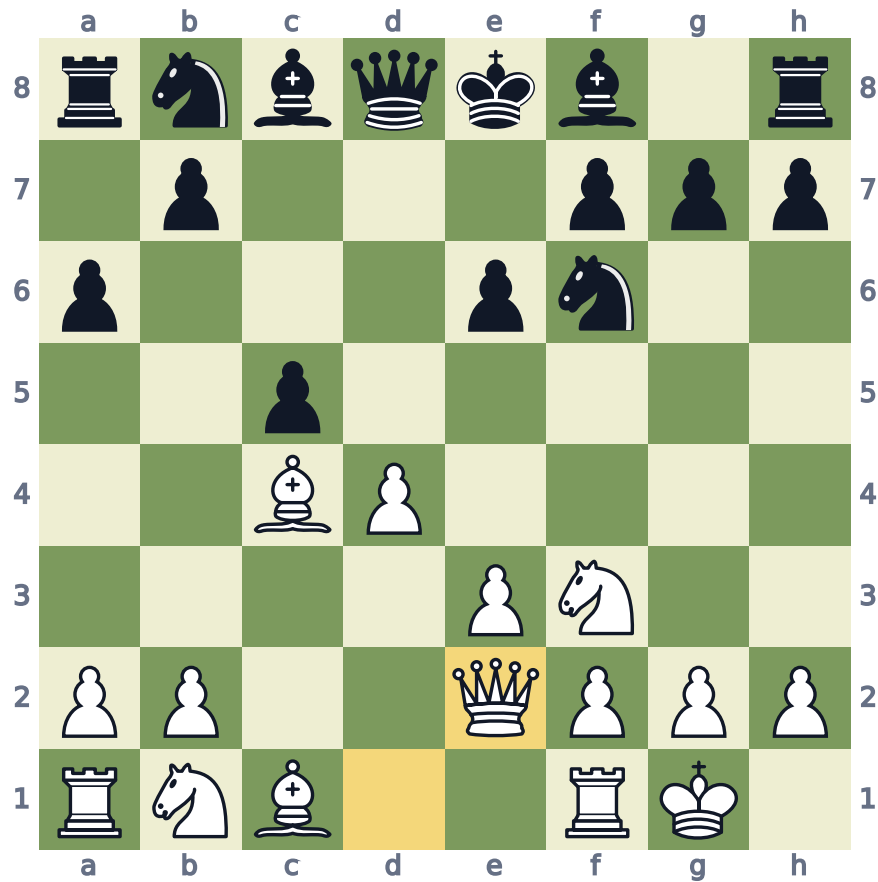
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 03

QGA central strike



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 c5 5. Bxc4 e6 6. O-O a6 7. Qe2

WHITE'S IDEA

Complete development and be ready for dxc5 or e4.

MAIN DANGER

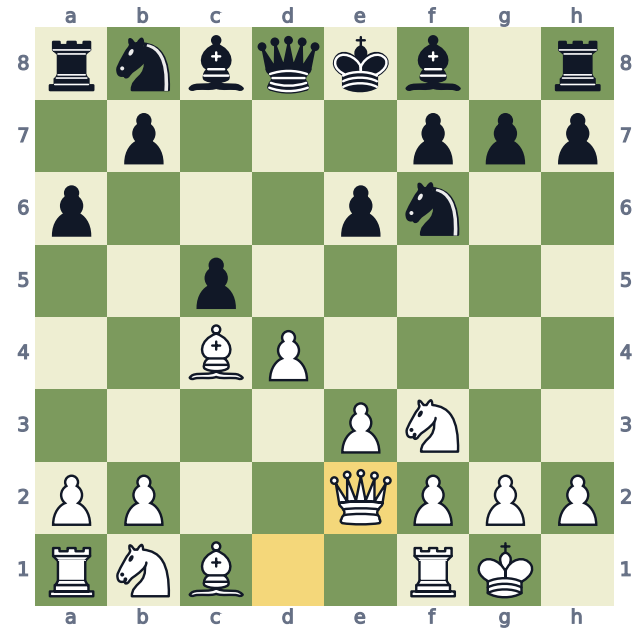
An automatic dxc5 can release Black's bishop with tempo.

BRANCH LOGIC 03

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

When Black plays ...c5, decide whether tension or exchange favors development.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.30 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. b5 Bd3 2. Nbd7 a4 3. c4 Bc2 4. Bb7 e4 5. Be7 Nc3

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 03

QGA central strike



YOUR TASK

White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 04

Early e4 in the QGA



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. e4 e5 4. Nf3 exd4 5. Bxc4 Bb4+ 6. Bd2 Bxd2+ 7. Nbx d2

WHITE'S IDEA

Use the broad center but accept simplification when Black checks and trades.

MAIN DANGER

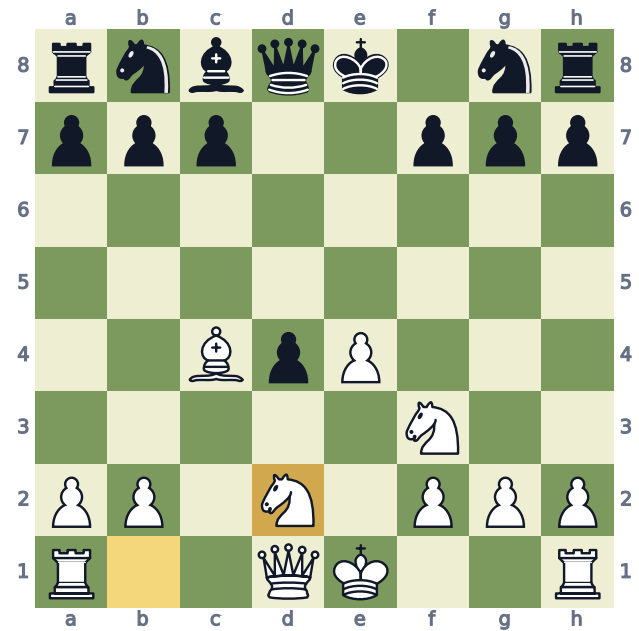
The e-pawn can become a target if White falls behind in development.

BRANCH LOGIC 04

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

e4 is ambitious; checks on b4 are Black's forcing reply.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

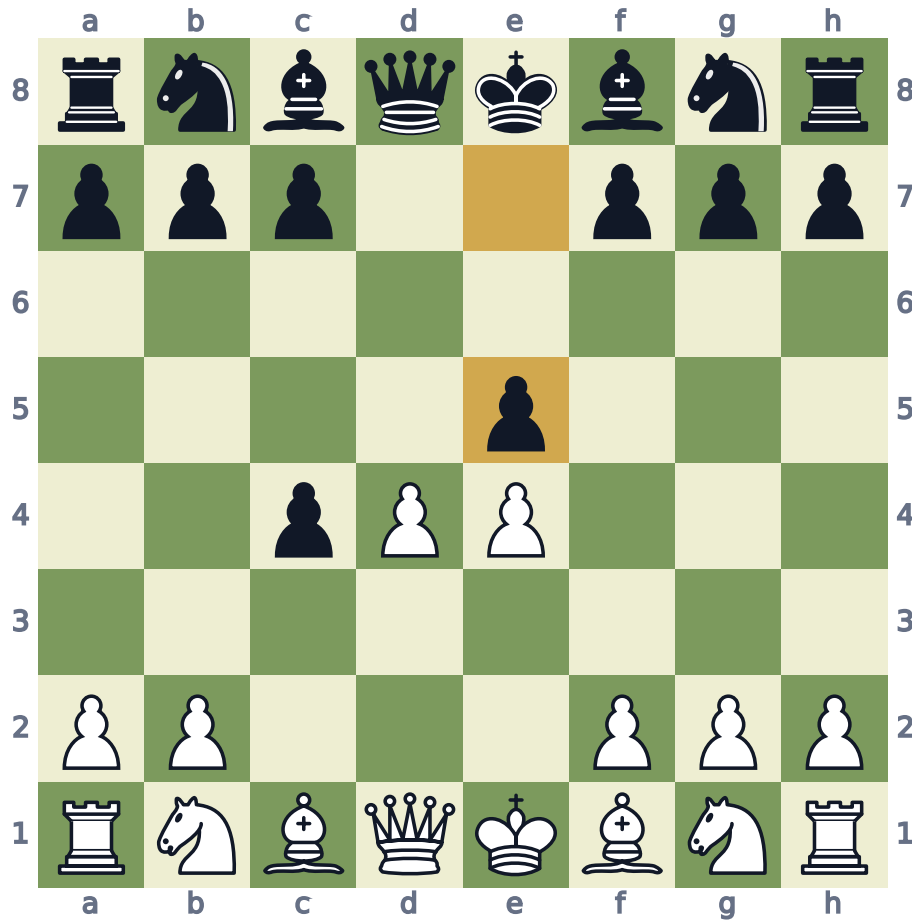
Position estimate: +0.25 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Nh6 Rc1 2. O-O O-O 3. c5 Bd5 4. Nd7

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 04

Early e4 in the QGA



YOUR TASK

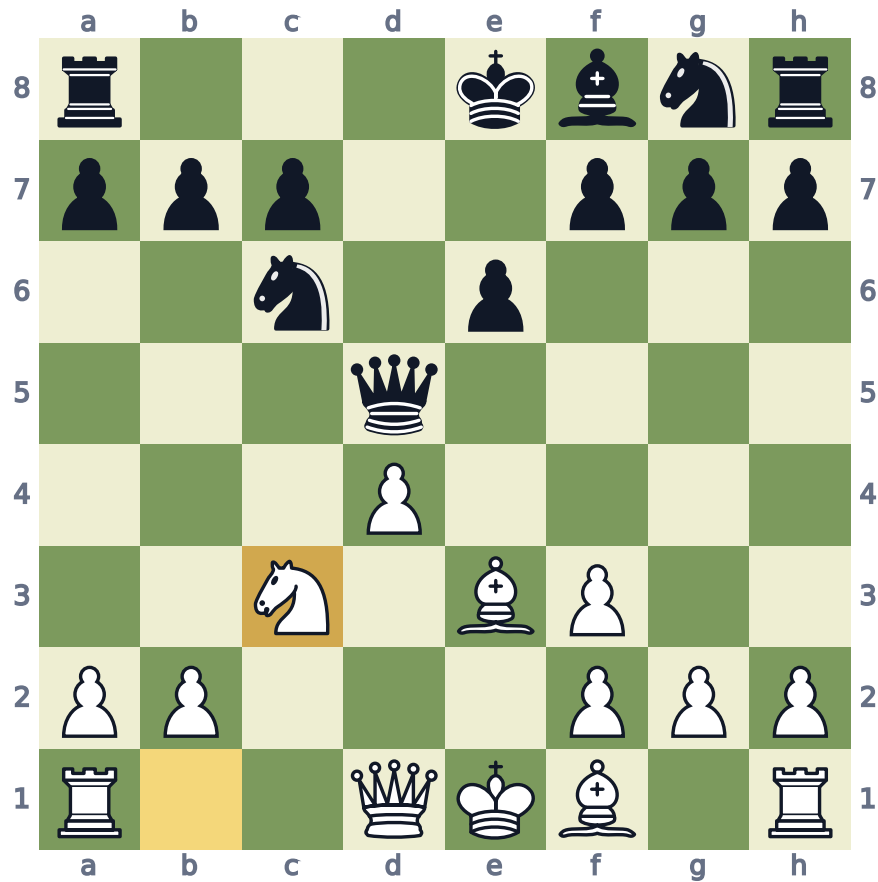
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 05

Chigorin Defense



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nc6 3. Nf3 Bg4 4. cxd5 Bxf3 5. exf3 Qxd5 6. Be3 e6 7. Nc3

WHITE'S IDEA

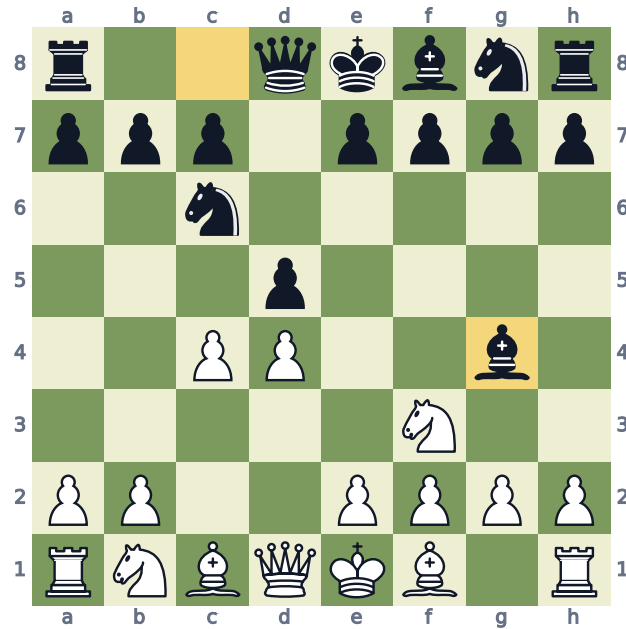
Exchange on d5 and gain the bishop pair without losing central control.

MAIN DANGER

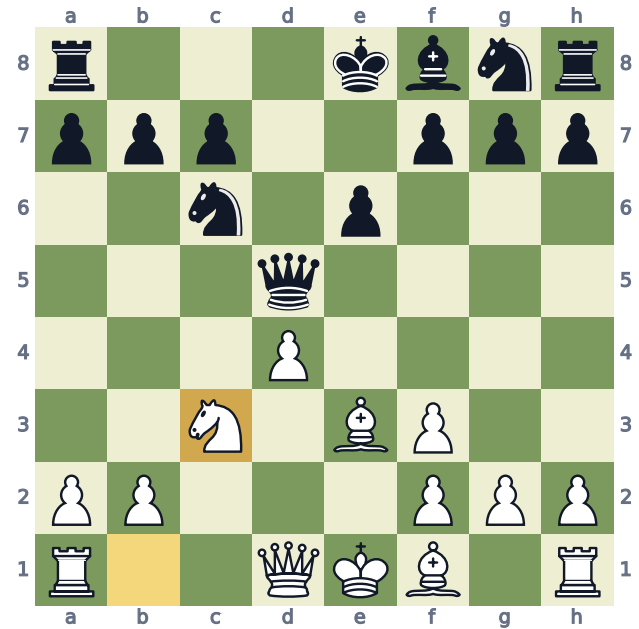
The doubled f-pawns are acceptable only with active development.

BRANCH LOGIC 05

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

...Nc6 blocks the c-pawn, so challenge d5 early.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

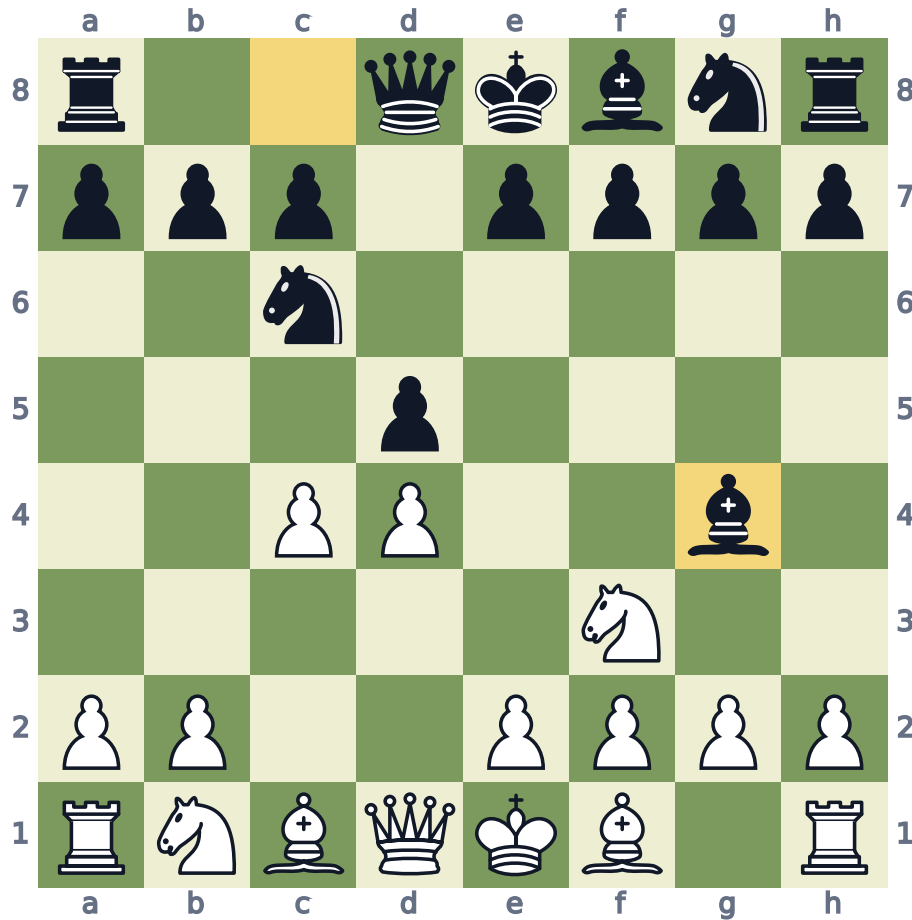
Position estimate: +0.43 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Qd6 a3 2. Nf6 Qc2 3. Nd5 Nxd5 4. Qxd5 O-O-O 5. O-O-O Bc4

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 05

Chigorin Defense



YOUR TASK

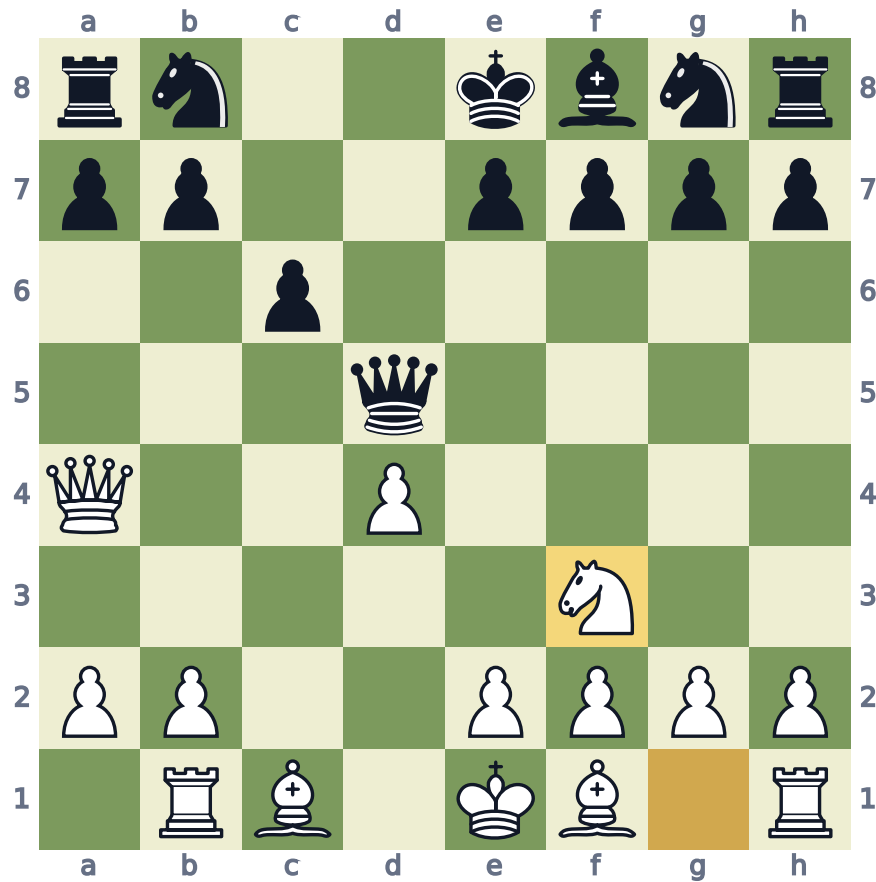
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 06

Baltic Defense



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Bf5 3. cxd5 Bxb1 4. Qa4+ c6 5. Rxb1 Qxd5 6. Nf3

WHITE'S IDEA

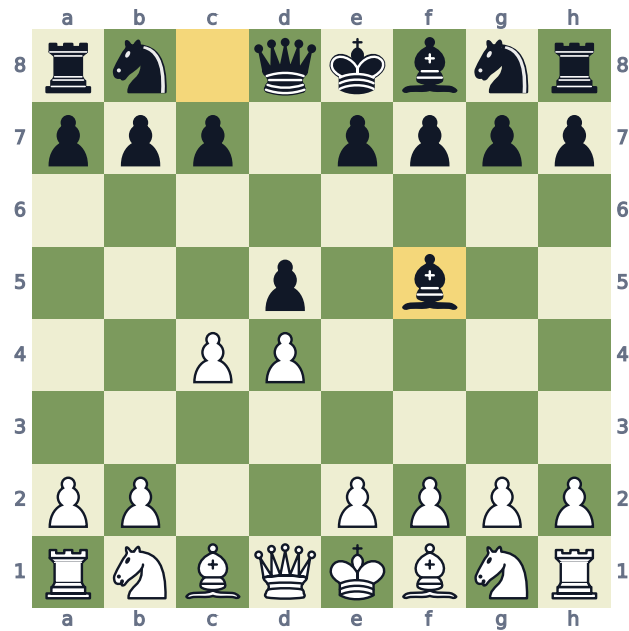
Use the queen check to regain time and finish development.

MAIN DANGER

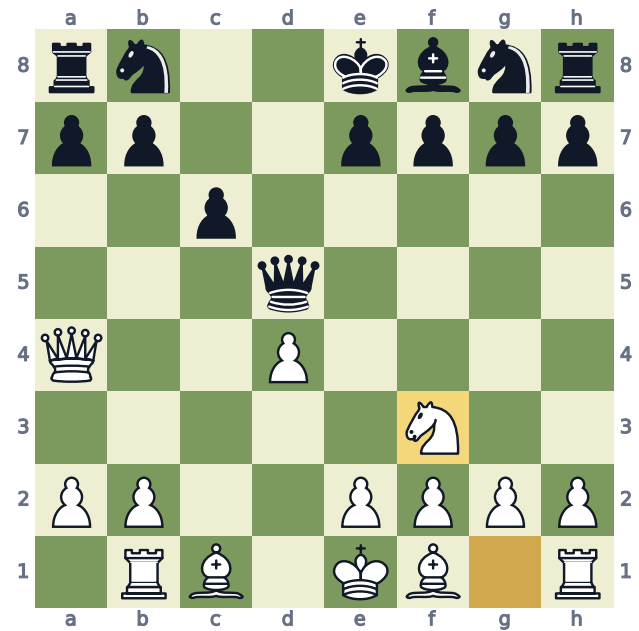
The rook on b1 can become exposed along the b-file.

BRANCH LOGIC 06

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 4 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

An early ...Bf5 leaves b7 and the queen side sensitive to Qa4+.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

Position estimate: +0.71 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. Nd7 e3 2. Qf5 Ra1 3. e5 Bd2 4. Bd6 dxe5 5. Nxe5 Nxe5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 06

Baltic Defense



YOUR TASK

White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 07

Marshall Defense



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 Nf6 3. cxd5 Nxd5 4. Nf3 e6 5. e4 Bb4+ 6. Bd2 Bxd2+ 7. Qxd2 Nf6 8. Nc3

WHITE'S IDEA

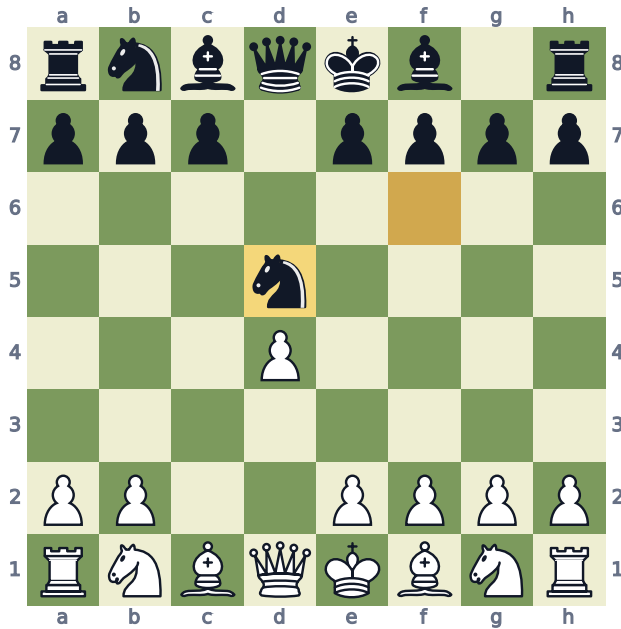
Take central space while answering the forcing check accurately.

MAIN DANGER

The broad center must be supported against ...c5.

BRANCH LOGIC 07

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

...Nf6 without ...e6 or ...c6 permits cxd5 and e4.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

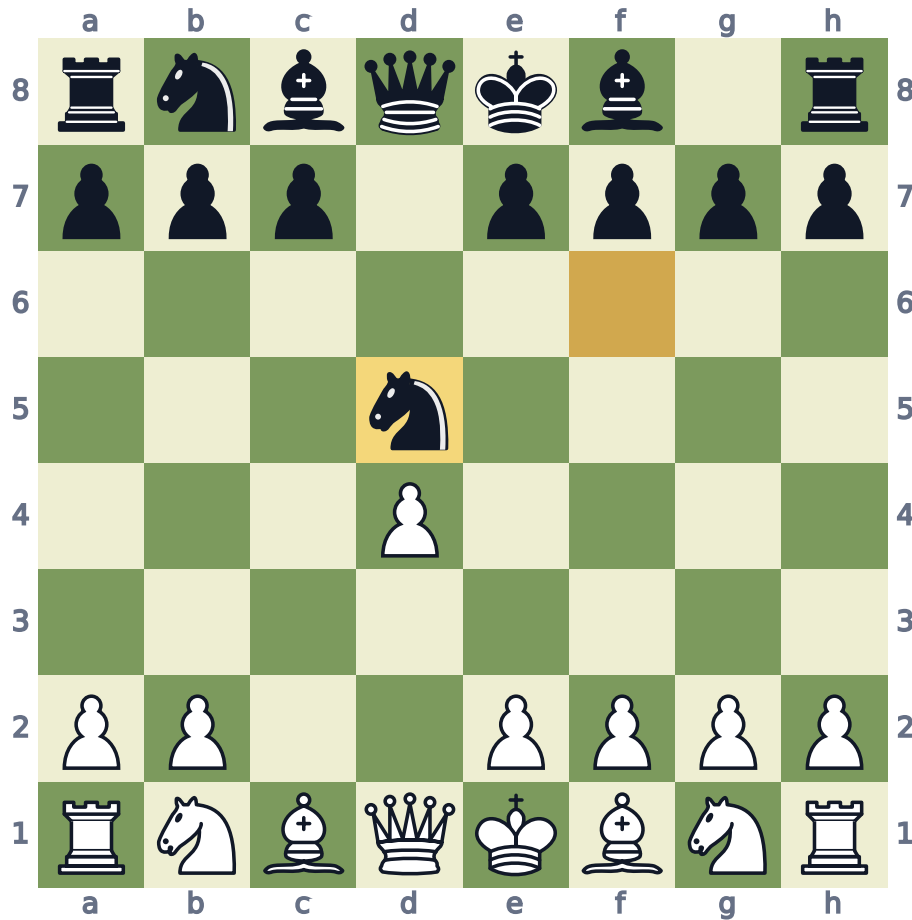
Position estimate: +1.15 for White (White is clearly better). Principal continuation: 1. O-O h4 2. Nbd7 e5 3. Nd5 Ng5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 07

Marshall Defense



YOUR TASK

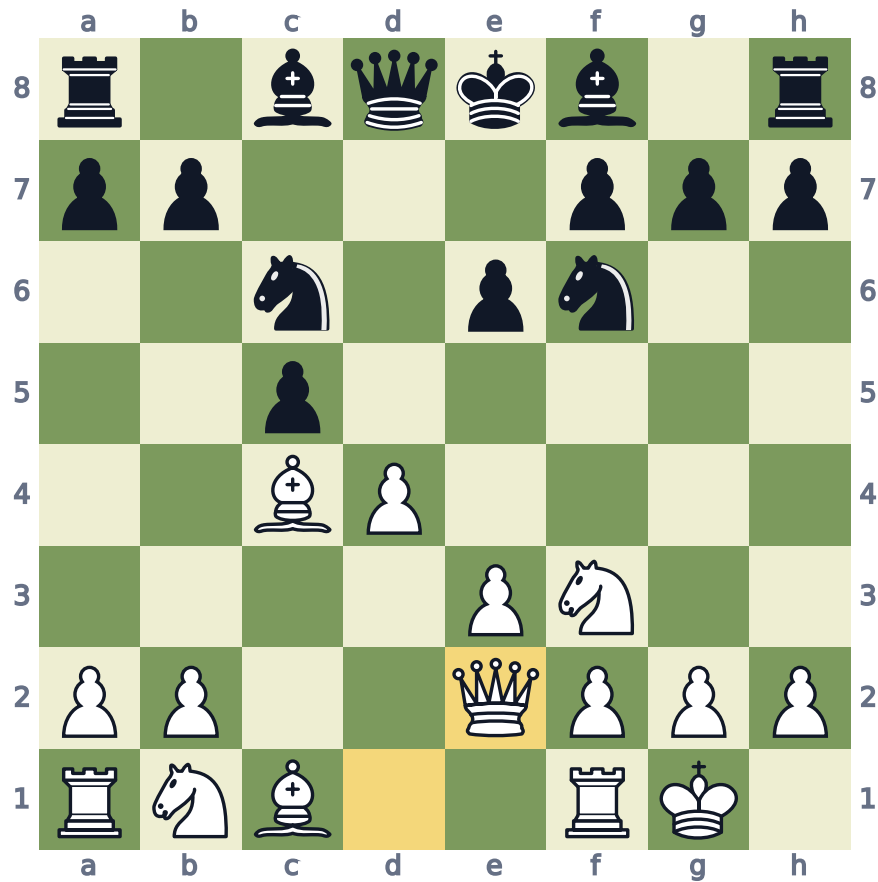
White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

REPERTOIRE BRANCH 08

QGA quiet line



COURSE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 e6 4. e3 Nf6 5. Bxc4 c5 6. O-O Nc6 7. Qe2

WHITE'S IDEA

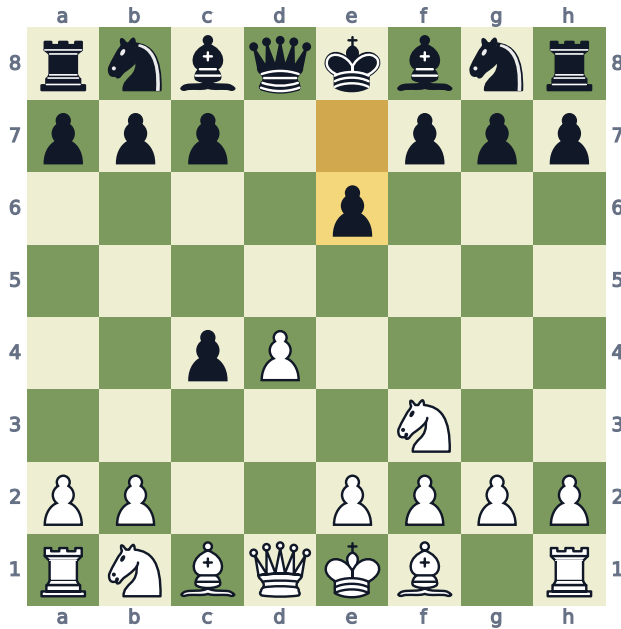
Use normal development and retain several healthy central choices.

MAIN DANGER

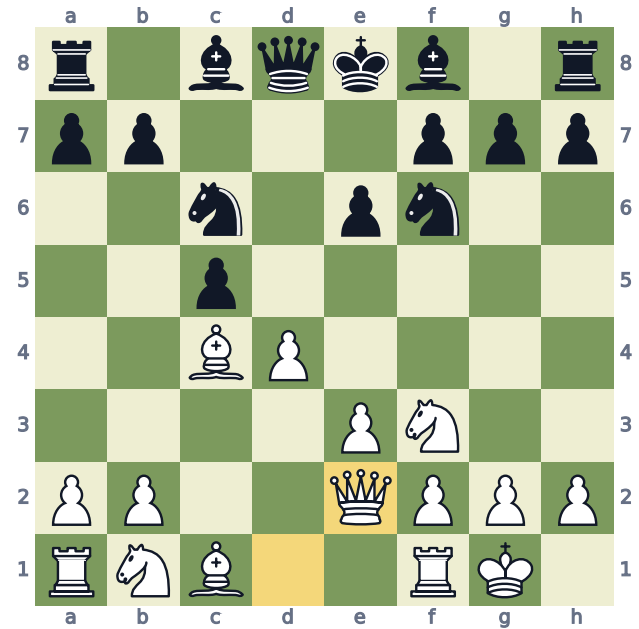
Trying to prove too much can create targets instead of an advantage.

BRANCH LOGIC 08

Why the moves belong together



AFTER 6 PLIES



COURSE DESTINATION

MEMORY HOOK

A recovered pawn plus completed development is already a successful opening.

ENGINE CONTINUATION

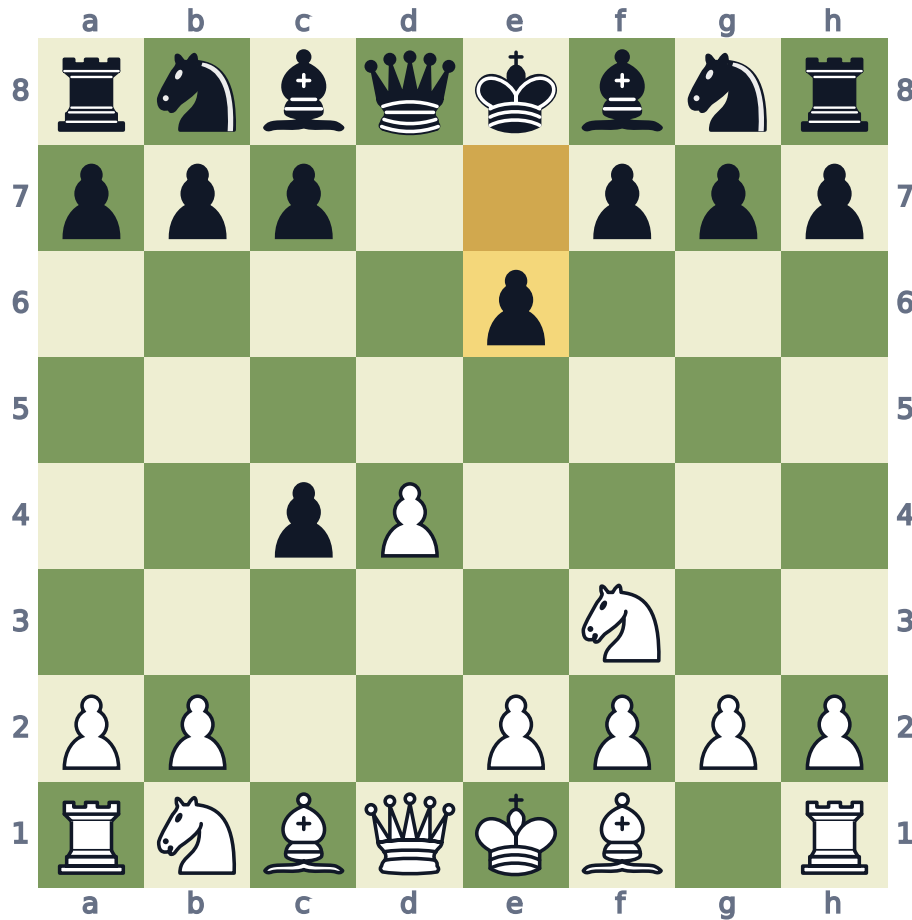
Position estimate: +0.46 for White (White is slightly better). Principal continuation: 1. a6 Nc3 2. b5 Bb3 3. Bb7 Rd1 4. Be7 d5 5. exd5 Nxd5

BOUNDARY CONDITION

Use the course line as a reliable destination, but recalculate when Black changes the center, creates a forcing threat, or gains a tactical tempo.

RECALL TEST 08

QGA quiet line



YOUR TASK

White to move. Name Black's opening setup, choose the repertoire move, and explain its purpose. Then give Black's most challenging reply and one plan for the resulting structure. Do not move the pieces until the full answer is spoken or written.

SCORING

2 move | 2 purpose | 2 Black reply | 2 structure plan | 1 tactical check | 1 notation = 10

ANSWER SECTION

Recall solutions begin here

PROTECT THE TRAINING EFFECT

Do not read a solution until you have committed to a move and purpose. A matching move without the correct reason earns partial credit. If the course move is not the engine's first choice, compare plans rather than treating the engine as a memorization oracle.

ERROR LABELS

M = move-order memory | T = tactical oversight | P = plan misunderstanding | V = visualization | C = calculation | R = rushed recognition

REPAIR RULE

Every miss must produce a question you can use in future games. Example: 'When Black supports d5 with c6, which pawn break or recovery method does my repertoire use?'

SOLUTIONS

Answers 1-3

01. QGA CLASSICAL RECOVERY

Course move: Bxc4. Purpose: Recover c4 through development and accept a clean active endgame. Engine comparison: 1. Bxc4 c5 2. O-O a6 3. dxc5 Bxc5 4. Qxd8+ Kxd8 5. Be2 Ke7 (+0.34 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: Do not fear queen trades when development and structure are healthy.

02. QGA ...B5 EXPANSION

Course move: e3. Purpose: Undermine the pawn chain rather than chase its front pawn. Engine comparison: 1. e3 c5 2. Bxc4 e6 3. O-O a6 4. dxc5 Qxd1 5. Rxd1 Bxc5 (+0.39 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: Opening the a-file can expose the rook if geometry is ignored.

03. QGA CENTRAL STRIKE

Course move: e3. Purpose: Complete development and be ready for dxc5 or e4. Engine comparison: 1. e3 c5 2. Bxc4 e6 3. O-O a6 4. dxc5 Qxd1 5. Rxd1 Bxc5 (+0.39 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: An automatic dxc5 can release Black's bishop with tempo.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 4-6

04. EARLY E4 IN THE QGA

Course move: Nf3. Purpose: Use the broad center but accept simplification when Black checks and trades.

Engine comparison: 1. Nf3 Bb4+ 2. Bd2 Bxd2+ 3. Nbx d2 exd4 4. Bxc4 Nc6 5. O-O Nge7 (+0.38 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: The e-pawn can become a target if White falls behind in development.

05. CHIGORIN DEFENSE

Course move: cxd5. Purpose: Exchange on d5 and gain the bishop pair without losing central control. Engine

comparison: 1. cxd5 Bxf3 2. gxf3 Qxd5 3. e3 Nf6 4. Bd2 O-O-O 5. Nc3 Qd7 (+0.71 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: The doubled f-pawns are acceptable only with active development.

06. BALTIC DEFENSE

Course move: cxd5. Purpose: Use the queen check to regain time and finish development. Engine comparison: 1. cxd5 Bxb1 2. Rxb1 Qxd5 3. e3 e6 4. a3 Nd7 (+0.84 for White (White is clearly better)). Warning: The rook on b1 can become exposed along the b-file.

SOLUTIONS

Answers 7-8

07. MARSHALL DEFENSE

Course move: Nf3. Purpose: Take central space while answering the forcing check accurately. Engine comparison: 1. Nf3 Nb6 2. Nc3 g6 3. h3 Bg7 4. e4 O-O 5. Be2 Nc6 (+0.95 for White (White is clearly better)). Warning: The broad center must be supported against ...c5.

08. QGA QUIET LINE

Course move: e3. Purpose: Use normal development and retain several healthy central choices. Engine comparison: 1. e3 Nf6 2. Bxc4 c5 3. O-O a6 4. a4 Be7 5. dxc5 Qxd1 (+0.38 for White (White is slightly better)). Warning: Trying to prove too much can create targets instead of an advantage.

VOLUME REVIEW

Make the repertoire usable

REVIEW TASK 1

Reconstruct every branch from the first move without looking.

REVIEW TASK 2

For each branch, explain one Black plan and one White plan.

REVIEW TASK 3

Shuffle the recall positions so the chapter title cannot reveal the answer.

REVIEW TASK 4

Play each starting position against Fritz from both sides.

REVIEW TASK 5

Add mistakes from your own games to the PGN as new training positions.

REVIEW TASK 6

Retest the weakest three branches after 1, 3, 7, 14, 30, and 60 days.

GRADUATION STANDARD

Score at least 80 percent twice, one week apart, and explain every move in plain language. Then maintain the volume through your own games instead of rereading it continuously.